

Cost of Pampering

50%

parents want children to move ahead in life, even if it puts pressure on them.

40%

children use computers, mobile phones, DVD players in 50% Indian homes.

84%

parents buy what children want them to buy—from TV to cars to mobile phones.

70%

parents admit that their children cite "everybody has one" as a ground for nagging.

Source: Kantar Media Study on family values, 2007; Cartoon Network surveys, 2005-07

against parental rage, passed on the wedding CD to a television channel, hitchhiked her way to Delhi, roped in high-profile lawyers to canvass the cause, moved the high court for protection and sought endless rounds of blessings from gods and politicians in a mayhem of media melodrama. "I love my dad," she said after she had her way. "I gave her all the freedom. She was like my friend," added her father. And the nation sat rapt, breathless, through yet another jigsaw puzzle of parent-child dialogue.

This generation of parents believes in giving children every advantage, from cell phones with the latest bells and whistles to a generous allowance for that elite college abroad. But the good intentions are often overshadowed by negative effects: wilful children with a distorted sense of entitlement, who are unable to cope with life's disappointments. Now a growing number of experts think it's time to start teaching kids what's really important—values like hard work, delayed gratification, honesty and compassion.

It will be not a day too soon. Nearly 12.5 per cent school-going children are showing psychological disorders, reports a 2005 NIMHANS (National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences, Bangalore) survey on 2,064 chil-

dren. Doctors at the All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in Delhi, involved with mental health programmes at various schools, inform that a large number reveal conduct disorders. "They are increasingly found to be defiant, hostile and destructive," says Dr Manju Mehta, Professor of clinical psychology at AIIMS. In a recent VIMHANS survey, indiscipline emerges as the most common conduct disorder in school, followed by stealing, lying, truancy, aggressiveness and bullying. Other big issues are lack of attention and motivation. Nearly 10 per cent have experimented with smoking and 8 to 15 per cent with drugs, cite two more studies this year from AIIMS and VIMHANS. Suicide is the third largest killer of teenagers in India, shows a 2006 NIMHANS study.

"Words can't describe me," wrote 16-year-old Adnan Patrawala of Mumbai about himself on his Orkut profile. The words turned eerily prescient with his tragic murder on August 18 last year. But the more the reports of his underage driving and drinking, midnight trysts and poolside living seeped out, the more the nation asked anxious questions: how come a 16-year-old was allowed to drive a car? What sort of parental control are we talking about if an adolescent can call up home casually at midnight to say that he wouldn't show up?



Buying peace with 'yes': They have busy lives and tough schedules. Both clock over 12 hours at work, six days a week. To compensate for lost time, they are often overly-accommodating of their daughter Anaya's sometimes unjustified demands, she feels.

“She’s a sweet child, but she knows how to get me to say ‘yes’ to everything she wants.”

Raka Chakrawarti, 32, PR PROFESSIONAL, CHENNAI